

Home Automation at CES 2014

As always, the International CES held at Las Vegas this January featured a myriad of innovations, and overall the Internet of Things (IoT) appeared to be a popular theme with various interesting announcements related to sensor technology, home automation, wearable computing, digital health and fitness, automotive electronics and green technology. In this issue, let us look at a few interesting home automation products displayed there:

LG's new natural language messaging technology. LG displayed its useful HomeChat technology, which allows users to text their LG appliances as if they were humans. And they respond like humans too! For example, now it is possible to ask your LG refrigerator if it has enough milk in its dairy tray or vegetables in its crisper drawer. Or, you can text LG's Hom-Bot Square robotic vacuum cleaner to ask when it last cleaned the house, and perhaps instruct it to redo the job.

You can also use HomeChat to start a load of laundry on your new LG smart washer and dryer, monitor its status, download new cycles and receive push alerts via smartphones or an LG Smart TV!

Okidokeys, now get to know about these smart keys. The Open-Ways Group launched Okidokeys, a technology that allows you to lock and unlock home doors, garage doors or gates using multiple means such as smartphones, smart keys, smart wristbands and smart watches too. The kit is very simple to install, and the platform works with multiple communication protocols such as Bluetooth 4.0, near-field communications (NFC), radio frequency identification (RFID) and crypto-acoustic credential (CAC) technology. The Okidokeys virtual network, bridge and app allow users

to operate the lock remotely using iOS and Android devices.

Mother incarnate. If you really believe that nobody cares more for you than your mother, then Sen.se's Mother is just the right home management tool for you. It is not only a smart home product but also a smart life product, as it monitors those aspects that you consider essential for a happy and healthy life.

The Mother system is based on multi-purpose sensors, which the inventor calls the 'Motion Cookies.' You can stick these cookies onto almost anything, from toothbrushes and water jugs to pill boxes and refrigerators. So, you can set the system to watch how much junk food you eat or how much water you drink, whether you have taken your pills and walked enough or whether your home and kids are safe when you are away.

Apart from showing all the information in a well-designed app, Mother can also remind you about all these and more, depending on your settings. The cookies are colour-coded so you can use them for activity groups or different members of the family. You can keep reprogramming the system to help you in other ways, as and when needed.

Staple your gadgets together. Staples Connect Hub is for those who already have dozens of Internet-connected devices at home and are tired of managing the many apps that manage these! The Connect Hub pools together all your IoT gadgets so you can control everything from one app. Staples has already tied up with several device makers, and is in talks with many more.

We will look at more CES revelations in various categories in the coming episodes. ●

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Google crazy about IoT

Google seems to be going strong with its IoT plans. And, it is not all about the Google Glass. Last year, they bought Waze, a successful GPS navigation and traffic management tool, and they have embarked the 2014 journey by acquiring Nest, makers of the well-known smart thermostat. Around the same time, they (with others) also started the Open Automotive Alliance (OAA), aimed at popularising Android as an operating system for in-car infotainment systems. Trend-watchers hint that Google is working on creating APIs that connect Gmail and Google Drive to smart products. Their aim, apparently, is not to simply have successful products or operating systems for the IoT, but to be the preferred cloud service platform for the digital lifestyle ahead.

Wolfram tech for the IoT

British scientist, Stephen Wolfram, and his software company have been developing several strong IoT technologies towards the final goal of 'seamlessly'



connecting the things in the world. The Wolfram Language is a programming language that helps people to easily describe and compute about things in the world. In line with his belief that folks also need to first 'measure and interface' with those things, he has also launched the Wolfram Connected Devices Project (<http://devices.wolfram.com>), a database on IoT devices, which tracks the size, price and specifications of IoT products. The information is searchable, comparable and analysable through the computational knowledge engine, Wolfram Alpha. Currently, the database holds information about thousands of devices and components. Wolfram promises to seamlessly integrate it with his Data Framework and Data Sciences Platform, which will make it possible to scientifically study, compare and build IoT products, tools and platforms.